

The California Pepper Growing Cheat Sheet

Peppers reward patience and a warm spot. On the coast, a little planning around fog and timing makes all the difference between a slow, sulking plant and a basket of ripe fruit.

Which pepper for your space?

- **Small space or containers:** most peppers grow well in 5-gallon pots; jalapeno, shishito, and compact bells do nicely on a sunny patio.
- **Short coastal season:** choose early, small-fruited types (shishito, jalapeno, padron) that ripen before the cool returns.
- **Heat lovers:** serrano, habanero, and manzano want steady warmth; give them your warmest microclimate.
- **Reliable beginner picks:** bell, jalapeno, and shishito are forgiving and productive.

Pepper basics at a glance

Pepper	Days to maturity	Heat (SHU)	Spacing
Bell	70 to 90 days	Mild	18 to 24 in
Jalapeno	70 to 85 days	Medium (2,500 to 8,000)	18 to 24 in
Shishito	60 to 75 days	Mild (50 to 200)	18 to 24 in
Serrano	75 to 90 days	Hot (10,000 to 25,000)	18 to 24 in
Manzano	90 to 120 days	Hot (12,000 to 30,000)	24 to 36 in

SHU = Scoville heat units, a standard measure of a pepper's heat. Days to maturity are counted from transplant.

Starting and timing

- Peppers are a warm-season crop. Start seeds indoors 8 to 10 weeks before your last frost.
- Transplant out only after nights stay above about 55 F and the soil has warmed.
- In the fog belt, choose early or small-fruited types and use a warm microclimate like a south-facing wall or raised bed.

Watering and feeding

- Keep moisture even. Swings between wet and dry invite blossom-end rot.
- Mulch to hold moisture and steady the soil temperature.
- Go easy on nitrogen once flowering starts, or you get lush leaves and few fruits. Favor a balanced feed.

Coastal-California notes

- Most peppers start green and ripen to red, orange, or yellow. Ripening takes several extra weeks, and color brings more flavor and sweetness.
- Picking peppers green keeps the plant producing more fruit.
- Hot peppers need real warmth to size up and build heat. Without it, expect smaller, milder fruit.
- Extend the season with row cover, a wall for radiant heat, or a container you can move into the sun.

Top three beginner mistakes

1. Transplanting too early into cold soil, so peppers stall and sulk until it warms.
2. Over-feeding nitrogen, which gives you big leafy plants and almost no peppers.
3. Letting water swing wet to dry during fruiting, which causes blossom-end rot and dropped flowers.

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